

How an invite-only recruitment firm booked 108 opportunities in a two-week window, then paused outreach

A Netherlands-first search firm that places top talent, no-cure-no-pay. Here is the exact outbound system, the two copy moves that flipped it, and the real numbers.

Who they target

Not HR. The people who sign off on a hire.

- **Personas:** CEO, Founder, Head of Growth, Managing Director, HR Director. Decision makers, not gatekeepers.
- **Companies:** DTC and e-commerce is the sweet spot. B2B secondary.
- **Size filter:** 50+ employees and EUR 10M+ revenue. Hard floor, no exceptions.
- **Regions:** Netherlands first. Then USA. UK as fill-in.
- **Contacts per company:** max 2 to 3.
- **Signals that raise a company up the list:** recent funding, active senior job postings, headcount growth on LinkedIn, prior use of external recruiters.

No EBITDA test. This buyer is sized on revenue, headcount, and active hiring, not profit.

The play

Cold email on their own dedicated infrastructure: 64 sending domains, ~81 active inboxes, scaled to ~2,000 emails per day split 1,000 NL and 1,000 US.

Scrape - Store Leads as the primary DTC and e-commerce database. Pulled per city and region. - Every company cross-checked against everyone already contacted, so only fresh companies enter a campaign. - Lookalikes built off their existing placements as the seed audience.

Enrich - Email verification waterfall: FindyMail, then MillionVerifier, then Bounceban. - Clay pulls company and role signals per lead and feeds them into personalised first-line variables.

Send - Text-only, stop-on-reply, no tracking pixels. - 3 to 4 step sequence: invite opener, value and social-proof follow-up around day 3, a different angle or case study around day 4, optional break-up. - 4 to 6 copy variants per campaign in a

random split. Kill the losers, scale the winner. - CTA framed as an invitation, never a pitch.

The two moves that flipped it

1. Name the brands. Generic “we place great talent” got ignored. The switch that moved the number: naming the specific brands they had actually placed for, bundled by vertical. Beauty brands saw the beauty names. Fashion brands saw the fashion names. Proof the reader recognizes beats any adjective you can write.

2. The bakje-koffie radius play. Instead of “book a call,” pull the prospect’s office address, match the nearest good coffee spot, and open with it: “I’m near your office at [coffee spot] soon, worth grabbing 20 minutes?” Radius-matched in Clay against a curated venue list, with the closest spot and the distance dropped straight into the copy. It reads like someone who is genuinely in the neighborhood, not a sequence.

Under both sits the same frame: invite-only. It flips the script from “buy from us” to “you have been selected.”

The numbers

The winning two-week window, 1 to 16 May:

Metric	Result
Emails sent	~13,100
Reply rate	6.2%
Opportunities	108
Pipeline value	\$1.62M

For context, across the full 12 months:

Metric	Result
Emails sent	~103,600
Opportunities	180
Pipeline value	\$2.29M

Model: no-cure-no-pay at 20 to 30% of annual salary. One placement pays for a lot of sending.

Slow start, then a deliberate pause

- It did not start hot. Broad early sending sat under 1%, which is why the 12-month blended reply rate reads 1.49%. Volume without targeting is quiet.
- The lift came from three things: tight niche segmentation, naming the brands they had placed for, and personalised opening lines. Template copy sat at 0.9%, personalised hit 3.7%, a single-role niche campaign hit 4.2%.
- Dialed in, a single two-week window produced 108 opportunities at 6.2% reply and \$1.62M in pipeline.
- Then they paused outreach on purpose. The pipeline filled faster than the team could work it. When the machine produces more than you can handle, the right move is to stop sending, not keep pouring in.

The takeaway you can apply

The lever is not more sending. It is tighter targeting and proof the reader already knows. Name the brands you have delivered for, match them to the exact niche you are mailing, and personalise the first lines with real signals. That is the gap between 0.9% and 6.2%. Volume is easy to buy. Relevance is the moat.

Want this pointed at your recruitment pipeline? We build the whole engine: list, infrastructure, copy, campaigns, CRM. Book 30 minutes:
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